

WHEN YOU SEE ME

A SHORT STORY

by **Peace Adzo Medie**

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Adanna tiptoed past Susan's bedroom, down the spiral staircase, and past the kitchen where the cook was stuffing sliced pineapples into the blender for Susan's morning smoothie. She quietly crossed the marbled floor of the large sitting room, her steps quickening as she neared the front door, relief beginning to loosen the tension in her neck. But just as she reached out to turn the doorknob, she heard Susan's voice and froze.

"And where do you think you are going dressed like that?" the woman said, her gaze traveling up and down Adanna's body, the corners of her mouth pulled down in disapproval. This was an expression with which Adanna was familiar because Susan, who was her boss, was rarely pleased with anything. The woman was in an armchair in the furthest corner of the room, one arm on the armrest, the other under

her chin. Adanna had expected her to be up in her bedroom, getting ready for church, applying layers of makeup to her face until she no longer resembled herself. But she was not dressed. Her hair was in a black bonnet and the hem of her satin boubou, one she wore around the house, rested on the floor. She'd obviously parked herself in that chair, waiting to ambush Adanna.

Adanna opened her mouth twice before words came out. "Aunty, please I told you I was going out," she said, still holding on to the shiny doorknob. Susan's house was full of sparkly things.

"Going where?"

"To see my friend."

"Which friend?"

"James...my friend James."

"James, my friend James," Susan repeated mockingly, in a nasal tone. She then laughed dryly and stood up, one hand gathering and holding up the bottom half of the boubou so it wouldn't trip her. She was a short and plump woman with eyes that seemed constantly accusatory. One look from her and an innocent person could begin to feel guilty. Her skin was smooth and glossy like women who had won the genetic lottery or spent too much money on skincare products. Adanna knew that it was the latter; she'd met Susan's parents when they visited from Lagos.

When she was close enough that the sharp floral scent of her perfume, which she spritzed on her pulse points as soon as she got out of the shower, engulfed Adanna, Susan said, "Instead of going to church, or even sitting at home and busying yourself, you are going to see a boy." She nodded, agreeing with herself as she spoke.

Even though the woman was four inches shorter, Adanna took a step back and swallowed, the muscles in her neck now

so tense that they ached. She had lived with Susan since she came from Lagos with her sister, Amara, to work in Ghana. Amara had friends in Ghana who had called her with stories about life in the country: more jobs, less crime, a constant supply of electricity. Amara, who'd lost her shopkeeping job and had been unemployed for over a year, became convinced that their future was in Ghana. Adanna, who had dreams of going to university but had been selling vegetables alongside her mother in the market because her parents could not afford the fees when there were three younger siblings to care for, had listened as her sister told her that a friend in Accra had lined up jobs for them.

"You could save some money for university," Amara told her, as they both sat by the tray of rapidly-wilting lettuce on a day that was so hot that Adanna's head and shoulders were wet from when she'd splashed herself with cold water a few minutes before.

She was scared to leave home, to be so far away from her parents, but if Ghana would make university possible then she was willing to make the move. Besides, she would be with her big sister, and Amara had friends in Ghana.

Lucy, one of Amara's friends, had picked them up from the bus station in Circle and taken them to the room she shared with three other young women in a compound house in Madina. The house bordered a wide, uncovered gutter and was next to a busy local market where traders began opening their stalls as soon as they glimpsed daylight. The next day, Lucy had taken them to Ezekiel's shop, in that market, where Amara began working as a shopkeeper. Ezekiel, a grandfather who insisted on wearing skinny jeans and pointy shoes that made his feet look much longer than they were, came from a town not far from Adanna's mother's hometown. It was he who took Adanna to Susan's house in Cantonments.

“She’s from my hometown,” Ezekiel said with pride, as they drove into Susan’s landscaped compound. A gardener was busy trimming hedges, while a second gathered the leaves and branches into a wheelbarrow. There was the menacing sound of large dogs barking, coming from behind the house; Adanna sprinted from the car to the front door.

As Ezekiel fawningly greeted Susan, Adanna’s eyes had darted around what she would later learn was one of two sitting rooms, the less formal one where Susan entertained people she wasn’t trying to impress. Susan had been looking to hire a nanny for her twin daughters, Roseline and Rosa, who had just turned ten. “I want someone who can speak our language to the children, so they know where they come from,” she’d told Adanna after the housekeeper had brought her and Ezekiel glasses of water.

“I’m very fluent,” Adanna had assured the woman, as she carefully set her water glass on a coaster on the glossy wood of the centre table. The room looked like the homes she saw in Nollywood films; the cream carpet was plush under her bare feet, the leather armchair soft, the glittering crystal light fixture so large that she wondered if there was a risk of it pulling down the ceiling.

“Your fluency is not enough. I will need references,” Susan said as Ezekiel nodded. Why hadn’t he told Adanna about references before bringing her there?

“References?” Adanna asked. Where was she going to get references from? Her secondary school teachers?

“I’ve only worked with my mother...helping her in the market.”

“I will get the references myself,” Susan said, as if Adanna had not spoken.

When Adanna spoke to her mother a few days later, she heard that Susan had sent someone around to ask questions.

The person had even gone to their hometown.

“What do you expect? She’s a big woman. Did you not see her house? You think she will let you come and stay there without knowing about you and your people? If something happens, she needs to know where to go to complain,” Ezekiel had said, when she told him about Susan’s international investigation into her background. Now Adanna was employed by Susan, who didn’t want her going out on her one day off, especially when it was to see a man.

“I didn’t go out last week, or the week before,” Adanna said, holding her own. She had stood up to even more intimidating women than Susan, refusing to back down when other traders tried to steal her customers or blocked the path to her stall because they wanted shoppers to see their wares first. But she knew that she was at Susan’s mercy, so had to cool her fire when dealing with the woman.

“Why is James’ house the only place you like to go? Hmm? Everyday, James, James, James. You have refused to join the youth wing in church; you could be doing something holy with your time this Sunday morning. But no, you want to go and visit a boy. And look at the dress you are wearing. Displaying your thighs for everyone to see, behaving as if we don’t live in a dangerous world.”

Surprised, Adanna looked down at the knee-length dress, wondering if it had ridden up to reveal her thighs. Adanna was tall, her hips wide and the curves of her body noticeable; even a long sack could look revealing on her. So, no matter what she wore, Susan found a reason to complain.

“You know, she will fire you as soon as she gets a man,” Amara had told Adanna. Susan’s husband had run off to London with a mistress, without even bothering to first file for divorce. Adanna wondered if that was why she disapproved of James. Maybe she was angry with all men.

“Aunty Susan, please, this dress is not revealing my thighs. It’s at my knee,” she said, pointing to her knee.

“OK, carry on. You think you know better than me,” Susan replied, still glowering.

Adanna hesitated at the door, knowing Susan was daring her to leave. But how could she not? It had only been phone calls with James for the past three weeks because Susan had pulled this same act the last two Sundays. And James had already made it clear that things could not continue like that. He didn’t want to be in a relationship with someone he couldn’t see. She’d tried to explain to him that Susan was controlling, but he had snapped at her.

“Are you a child? Can’t you stand up for yourself? It’s your day off after all!”

“It’s true,” Adanna had said quietly, because James had a temper and she didn’t want him to start yelling at her on the phone. Old Adanna would have yelled right back at him but this new Adanna who was in Ghana without her parents and extended family, who needed James’ help in attending university, who wanted a way out of Susan’s house, could not afford to make James angry.

If she kept letting Susan prevent her from leaving the house, it would be the end of her relationship with James. James with his broad shoulders, James the university student who already had a job lined up in a bank and had more than once introduced her to friends as his future wife, James whose mother was a senior manager at one of the banks and frequently appeared on TV to give financial advice to women, James who didn’t care that she hadn’t attended university and worked as a nanny, who had promised to pay for her to attend university once he started working. Sure, he had a short fuse, but she reasoned that being shouted at every once in a while never killed anyone. If she stayed with James, he would

change her life. Was she supposed to give him up because her employer, who barely paid her enough to cover her basic needs, save, and send a bit back home to her parents, didn't approve of her having a boyfriend? Was she supposed to give him up, along with her dreams, to be at Susan's mercy? She shook her head, causing Susan to give her a curious look.

"I won't be long," Adanna said, and before the woman could speak again, she turned the doorknob.

In the trotro to James' house in Spintex, Adanna wondered what Susan would do. She needed the job, at least until she found a better paying one or enrolled in university with James' help. Since her first day, she'd made sure to work hard so that Susan would have no reason to complain. In the mornings, she was up before everyone, preparing breakfast for the twins and packing their lunches. She rode along when the driver dropped them off at their posh international school, and back at the house, cleaned their rooms, prepared their lunch, and lent a hand to the cook and housekeeper. She then rode with the driver to pick them up and after they had eaten and done their homework with the tutor that came every weekday, played with them in the backyard, pushing the swing or splashing in the pool until they were tired. It was then bath and bedtime. Some weeks, the only time she left the house was to take them to school and pick them up. She didn't mind the job, in fact the girls were sweet and easy, happy to have someone pay attention to them while their father was cavorting with his girlfriend in London and their mother was away at one of her many businesses in town. But Adanna was twenty and wanted to live. Her life could not be spent entirely behind the high walls of Susan's house. Especially not when her salary was a pittance. She had seen receipts and knew that Susan spent more on a single lunch with friends than she paid Adanna in a

month. She would be a fool to sacrifice her relationship with James to please the woman.

She had met him at the children's school. Tall with the kind of chest that made her long for a hug, he had come to pick up his niece. She'd seen his eyes on her when she stepped out of Susan's Range Rover. And as she watched, he'd begun scolding the security guards for not opening the gate quickly enough and making parents and guardians wait in the blazing sun.

Adanna had been pleased that someone was finally having a word with those security people who behaved as if the school gate was the portal to their kingdom.

"After you," he'd said to Adanna when the frowning guards pushed the gate open. He was smiling down at her as if he hadn't just told the head security guard to shut her "dirty mouth."

"Good afternoon," he'd said, when they were in the schoolyard.

"Good afternoon," she'd replied shyly, because there was something about the way he looked at her that made her self-conscious.

"Picking up your sister...or brother?" he asked.

"No, my boss's children. I'm their nanny," she said, wanting him to know that the Range Rover didn't belong to her. She'd expected him to lose interest after that, but he kept talking to her, even after the children had come out of their classrooms. And as she climbed into the car, the twins buckled into the backseat, he'd asked for her number, his irritated preteen niece by his side. From there it was late night phone calls and text messages that came all hours of the day until she began keeping her phone on silent so as not to annoy Susan with the notifications.

Today, James was waiting for her at the gate when she arrived. And he was frowning.

"I thought you said you were coming at 9?" he said, as though she had control over Susan, and the number of stops trotros made, and traffic in Accra.

"I'm sorry", she said, only wanting a quiet and peaceful morning. Susan had already done her head in and she needed a break. Besides, she knew he was that way because he wanted to have sex, and would calm down once they were done.

He held her hand and began hurrying her to the three-bedroom bungalow that was supposed to be the boys' quarters, but was his home. His oldest sister lived in the two-storey main house, which had been a wedding gift from their mother. Today, his sister was on the veranda in her Sunday best, a sleek dress with puffy sleeves that swallowed her arms, watching as the houseboy buffed her car. She resembled James but had dainty features.

"Good morning, sister," Adanna said with a slight curtsy, when she reached the veranda. This woman would have a say in whether James married her, so she had to be on her good side.

"Morning," the woman said politely, but without warmth.

"I don't think your sister likes me," she said to James, after they'd had sex and had migrated from the bed to the sofa.

"Why?"

"They way she speaks to me."

"That's just how she talks, she's quiet," James said, already switching on the TV to watch an action film she wasn't interested in. Was she supposed to believe that a person could leap from the ground into a helicopter that was hovering in the sky?

"Hmm," was all that Adanna said. She was too tired to get into an argument with James. And what good would it do her to make him angry?

They were halfway through the film when his friend Joe, and his girlfriend, Ama, rang the bell. Adanna, who hadn't bothered to put her dress back on and had instead tied a cloth around her chest, was surprised and irritated by the intrusion. She wanted to spend the day alone with James, not with Joe, a snob, who had asked Adanna what future there was in being a nanny the first time they met. The man, his forehead occupying too much space on his face, didn't like her and didn't care to hide it; but James didn't seem to notice his friend's rudeness. In fact, she thought Joe brought out the worst in James; he was always louder with Joe around, drinking more, swearing more, gossiping more about their mutual friends. And now, the man had forced himself into their quiet morning. She hurried to the bedroom to put on her dress.

"I like this film," Joe said, his voice booming, as if addressing an auditorium full of people, when he saw what they were watching. He plopped himself onto the sofa between James and Adanna. Ama, who seemed reluctant to ever leave her boyfriend's side, squeezed in beside him so that they were like sardines on the three-seater sofa. James didn't seem to mind, clapping Joe on the back, but Adanna was fuming. She got up and went to the bedroom. When James called out to her, she pretended to be asleep, and stayed that way until she heard Joe and Ama leave. She was sitting up in bed when James entered the room.

"How could you embarrass me like that?" he asked angrily. It seemed like he'd been holding it in, waiting for his friend to leave.

"What did I do?"

"You are asking me what you did? You don't have a brain?" he said, tapping his temple.

"Don't talk to me like that!" Adanna said, forgetting that she had decided to turn the other cheek when with James. She'd had enough. Of Susan, of him, of his sister, of Joe, of all

these people who thought they could treat her however they wanted, who thought they were better than her. Her breathing quickened.

“You couldn’t even offer my friends something to drink. You just got up and left. How do you think that makes me look? No respect!”

“The kitchen is three steps away from the sofa, you could have gotten them something to drink. You know Joe is not nice to me and I don’t like to be around him.”

“Is it my job to serve drinks?”

“Nonsense, don’t you have hands?” she asked, before she could stop herself.

For a moment, they were both frozen. She because she dreaded what her words would provoke and he because he was stunned.

Before she could decide what to say or do next, he grabbed her by the collar and pulled her up until they were face to face, his nostrils menacing in how they flared with each breath.

“How dare you speak to me like that!” he said, holding on to her collar and shaking her as he spoke. Her head swung painfully back and forth with each movement of his hands, and she wondered if there was a risk of it becoming detached from her spine.

She put a hand on his fist, trying to stop him, but that seemed to make him angrier because he shook her more violently and when she cried out, pushed her back onto the bed. He then stood at the foot of the bed, glaring down at her, leaving only when she began to weep. Adanna sat up, her face damp with tears, and rubbed her neck; she knew she had to leave. James was not in the sitting room when she walked out so she put on her shoes and fled. His sister, who’d returned from church, was on her perch on the veranda and from how the woman was closely studying her, Adanna knew she’d heard

everything.

In the trotro back, Adanna was shaking. She'd never thought James capable of this. She'd seen him lose his temper many times, and once, get into a fistfight with a man in a restaurant's parking lot, because the man had scratched his car while pulling into a tight parking spot, but it had never crossed her mind that he would lay a finger on her. She winced when she touched the base of her neck. Her head was throbbing and her shoulders hurt. How could she be with him after this? Her mother's youngest sister, Adanna's favourite aunt, had once been married to a man who was quick to strike her. One day he beat her so viciously that she lost an eye. He had served less than two months in prison while her aunt now wore sunglasses everywhere, even at night, and walked with a cane. Adanna had promised herself that she would never be with a man like that. No matter how bright the future James was promising, Adanna didn't want to live in the shadow of his temper.

When she arrived home, Susan was with about twelve of her church ladies in the bigger sitting room, having one of their church meetings, which was usually about planning one event or the other. They seemed to be more of a social club than a church group. Susan was the leader of the women's group and liked to regularly summon them like they were children. And to reward them for their obedience, she would give them little gifts that she bought on her travels, chocolate, and scarves, and jewellery that faded if worn too many times. Today, when Adanna greeted, only one of them, Florence, responded. The rest only glared at her as if she had deeply wronged them. Adanna quietly climbed the steps to her bedroom. This was why she had no interest in their church or any church for that matter. These so-called people of God who refused to show kindness. Susan was a big woman in the church but had no qualms about traveling to China to buy a handbag for the equivalent of one hundred cedis and selling

it in one of her stores for a thousand cedis. Susan who barely paid Adanna enough, such that she couldn't save to buy a bus ticket to go home to visit her mother, yet bought dog food that was more than what Adanna earned each week. Susan and her friends who gossiped and judged other people in the church while interspersing every sentence with 'amen'. They made Christianity repellent.

Downstairs, Florence listened as Susan began complaining about Adanna again.

"You see what she was wearing? You see my problem?"

The group muttered their agreement; their mouths stuffed with the meatballs that Susan's cook had served. These people acted like they didn't have food in their homes, bowing and scraping before Susan because she invited them into her showy house and fed them.

One of the women, Ophelia, who Florence had never heard say a good word about anyone, spoke up as soon as she'd swallowed the food in her mouth. "These young girls of today, that's how they are o," she said, speaking with her whole face, her drawn on eyebrow moving up and down with each word.

Florence could see nothing wrong with Adanna's outfit but didn't speak up. She knew dissent would not be well received and did not feel like fighting with these women; it had already been a long day. But on the way home, in the car in which one of the women, Salome, was giving her a lift, she couldn't help herself.

"There was nothing wrong with that girl's dress," she said, from the passenger seat of the Toyota, which Salome had told everyone was a push present from her husband when she bore a son after three girls. Like Susan, she was a Nigerian and was the woman that Florence liked best in the group; she could be annoying, going on and on about her husband as if he

was a god, but she wasn't meanspirited like some of the other women.

Salome stiffened at Florence's words, her eyes scanned the back seat as if there was someone else sitting there that could report her to Susan, then quietly said, "It's true."

"The way she was talking, you would have thought the girl went out naked," Florence said, emboldened by those meagre words of agreement from Salome.

"You know Sister Susan," Salome said, her eyes now on the Madina road where the traffic lights were not working and the intersection was a knot of cars, "she has always been like that, even when I knew her in Lagos," Salome said.

"Really?"

"Hmm," Salome said.

"Ehn?" Florence said again, fishing for more.

But Salome only said, "Hmm," again.

It was clear that the woman, eyes now fixed on the road, wasn't going to say anything more, so Florence dropped the matter and began to complain about the traffic.

Later, in the sitting room of her three-bedroom house in Adenta, which she shared with her husband and two children, she told her husband about Adanna and Susan.

"I don't even know why you go to that woman's house. From everything you've told me, she's not a nice person," he said. The children were in bed, and it was only the two of them watching GTV news.

"She's the leader; I can't be in the group and not attend meetings."

"But do the meetings have to be in her house?"

"Hmm, you're right," she said, standing up with her glass of water. Godfred was always the last to go to bed.

Adanna realised she'd left her phone, the most valuable thing she owned, at James' house, only after she arrived home.

She'd been so shaken by his aggression that she'd spent the bus ride going over the afternoon's events, blaming herself for provoking him and then being angry that she was blaming herself when there was nothing she had done that warranted that behaviour from him. It was now too late for her to return to his house for the phone, and she knew Susan would make a scene if she left the house a second time. She decided she would go back in the morning. James didn't have lectures on Monday morning and usually stayed home.

So, the next morning, after dropping off the children, she took a trotto to James' house. Susan would surely fire her if she heard that Adanna had used the Range Rover to run a personal errand. In fact, the driver would not even have agreed to take her to James'. He was like a robot, acting only on the prompts that Susan input into him each morning before she left for work.

She hesitated at James' gate, her heart thudding. She didn't want to be there but it wouldn't be easy to replace the phone. She had saved for many months to buy it. She took a deep breath and pressed the bell. It was James who opened the gate, his face breaking into a smile as if yesterday had not happened.

"How are you?" he said, after hugging her, not seeming to notice that her hands were limp by her sides.

"I left my phone in your room," Adanna said stiffly. She'd promised herself that she would be calm, collect her phone, and leave. The last thing she wanted was for him to become agitated.

"I saw it. I was going to bring it today. But I'm glad you're here," he said, now attempting to hold her hand as they walked to his door.

She pulled her hand away, causing him to scowl.

Inside she asked, "Where is it?"

"Ah, but won't you even sit down first?"

"I have to go to work. You know how Auntie Susan is."

He went into the bedroom and returned with her phone.

"Will you come this weekend?" he asked, as he gave it to her.

"No," Adanna said angrily. Why was he behaving as if he hadn't grabbed her by the collar and shaken her until she feared her head would snap off? She had no plan of coming back to see him. If this was what he was doing while they were only boyfriend and girlfriend, what would he do when they were married?

"I think it's better we end this," she said, already walking out.

"End what?" he said, pulling her back inside by the arm.

"This. After what happened yesterday...I don't want this anymore."

He laughed dryly. "So, you are leaving me?"

Adanna nodded.

"Who are you to leave me? I should be the one to leave you!" he said.

She sucked her teeth and tried to pull her arm out of his grip, but he held on fast.

"I will decide when this is over!" he said, his hand around her arm tightening so much that she winced.

"Leave my hand!" she snapped, even though she'd planned not to raise her voice.

"You don't respect!" he shouted back, tugging so hard on her arm she feared he would rip it out of the socket.

"Stop it!" she said, her voice sharp with pain and panic.

His response was to release her arm and push her onto the sofa. She had barely found her voice when he landed on top of her, painfully knocking the air out of her chest. She was still struggling to breathe when he lifted her skirt and raped her.

Adanna didn't remember much from her trotro ride home, only a throbbing in her head that made her shut her eyes. In the house, she locked herself in her room. When the driver came to tell her that it was time to pick up the children, she didn't open the door, so he went alone. When the children came home and knocked on her door, she didn't come out either. It was Susan's banging and threat to break down the door later that night that caused her to open it.

"What is wrong with you?" the woman asked brusquely when she saw Adanna's tear-stained face and red eyes. The children were in bed and the house was quiet.

Adanna didn't speak.

"Did you not hear me?"

Susan was the last person that Adanna wanted to speak with, but who else was there? Her parents were far away and couldn't do anything. They couldn't even afford the bus fare to come to Ghana. Her sister, who shared a shabby room with three other young women, had her own struggles and would only cry with her. Since Susan barely allowed her to leave the house, she hadn't made any friends in Ghana. Where could she go? She'd heard the police were not nice to Nigerians, and what would happen if they found out that she was working without a work permit? Susan was the only one who could possibly help her.

"Aunty, it's James."

"James? That boy?"

Adanna nodded.

"Ehn hehn, what about him?"

"He attacked me," Adanna said.

"Attacked you how?" Susan said impatiently.

"He raped me," Adanna said quietly.

"Raped you how? Isn't he your boyfriend?"

"He was...but still."

"Well, you see what I've been telling you? Going to his

house, wearing those short dresses, you see? If you give men the opportunity, they will take advantage of you. That is what I've been trying to tell you all along, but you've refused to listen. Now you see! Make sure you take the children to school tomorrow. None of this sitting in your room and crying as if someone has died," she said before she walked away.

Adanna felt like there was a hand squeezing her throat.

She called her sister the next day and told her what had happened. As expected, Amara had cried and told her to be strong. Ezekiel's shop didn't close until 9pm and she wasn't allowed breaks, so she couldn't come and see Adanna. Adanna decided that she would go to see her sister.

"Sorry," Amara repeated, as she hugged Adanna, gently patting her back. They were standing at the rear of the store, at the end of a long aisle of cheap plastic goods.

"I can't believe he did this to me. Look at how he scratched me," a teary Adanna said, showing Amara her arm.

"Sorry. Hmm. These things happen all the time. It even happened to Mary."

"Mary? When?" Adanna asked. Mary was one of Amara's roommates. It had taken them a couple of days to figure out that Mary was a sex worker, that every evening when she dressed for what they'd thought was work in a bar, it was to stand by the main road to pick up clients.

"More than once. Even a few weeks ago. She said the man was one of her clients, a regular, and still, he did that to her. You should have seen the marks on her."

"Did she report it to the police?"

"Police? They will just say she's ashawo and that will be the end of it. Even you, if you tell anyone they will say, 'Who sent you? Why did you go to his house? What were you wearing?' Nothing will come of it."

"That's what Auntie Susan said when I told her."

"I'm not surprised. That's how people are. They never blame the rapist; they will rather blame you. If you're not lucky, they will even say you're lying," Amara said quietly.

The two stood at the back of the shop, shoulders sagging, until Ezekiel yelled at Amara to come back to work.

Susan was waiting for Adanna when she arrived home.

"So you decided to go out, eh? You think you're your own boss?" Her voice was like a cracking whip. She had on a robe, and her hair was gathered in her black satin bonnet.

"I only went to see my sister to tell her what happened."

"After I warned you to stay in this house? And didn't I tell you to leave that matter? You don't have ears?"

"But Auntie Susan, how can I drop it? He raped me," Adanna said angrily. She was so tired of the woman, of biting her tongue.

"Don't raise your voice at me! Since you don't want to listen, pack your things and leave my house. I don't want you near my children with this behaviour. Pack your things now and leave!"

"But Auntie, where will I go?" Adanna said, her voice subdued now.

"That is not my concern. Carry your troubles and leave my house. Now now!"

That night, Adanna shared Amara's twin bed, both of them on their sides, because that was the only way they could fit. Around them, Amara's three roommates snored. Before they fell asleep, they'd all told her that going to the police would be a waste of time.

"Who will even mind you if you say you are going to the police to report a Ghanaian man?" Amina, the oldest among them had said, when Adanna told her she wanted James to pay for what he had done. Mary, who'd been mostly quiet, had

nodded.

Adanna knew Amina was right, but as she lay in bed, all she could think about was James walking free after what he'd done to her. She had no job, no money, and was sharing a bunk bed with her sister, squeezed so tightly together that every part of their bodies touched, but all she could think about was wiping the smile off James' face.

"Where's Adanna?" Florence asked Susan when their meeting ended. It was Sunday and the woman had summoned them to another pointless gathering. Florence had begun to think that Susan just wanted company. Because why insist they all come to her house to discuss decorations for the coming anniversary celebrations? They could have done it at church after the service.

"Adanna?" Susan said, as if no one with that name had ever lived in her house.

"Yes, your nanny," Florence said. Florence liked the girl, who was always respectful and had a smile on her face when Florence visited the house.

"Ah, that girl. I had to kick her out. She wore a short dress, went to her boyfriend's house and then came back crying that he had raped her. Can you believe it? How can a boyfriend even rape a girlfriend? And when I told her to drop the matter she refused. I didn't want her in my house with my twins anymore."

"So you didn't even take her to the hospital?" Florence asked, her voice so hard that the other women who were busy stuffing leftover cupcakes into their bags became still.

"Take her to the hospital because she had sex with her boyfriend? Let's be serious here," Susan said and sucked her teeth.

When Florence only stared at her, mouth open, Susan said with irritation, "What?"

“What are you saying, that a boyfriend cannot rape his girlfriend, that a husband cannot rape his wife? It doesn’t matter the relationship; as long as she says she doesn’t want it, it is rape. If the person doesn’t agree, it is rape. Simple!” Florence said.

“Rubbish! If she didn’t want to have sex with him, she shouldn’t have gone to his house. Simple! I advised her to stay at home, but she refused to listen. It is because we live in a dangerous world that I was advising her to stay at home but she didn’t care about what I had to say. Tomorrow, when an older person gives her advice, she will listen,” Susan replied, thrusting her forefinger at Florence as she spoke. She looked like she was about to strike her.

Florence shook her head, anger and disbelief causing her to go quiet. Once, when she was about Adanna’s age, she too had been raped by a nice boy, but had been too afraid to tell anyone.

Around her, none of the other women spoke up.

In the car ride home with Salome, she was fuming.

“Florence, this is someone’s private business, we can’t get involved.”

“We can’t get involved? Those women gossip about people’s private business all the time, but suddenly we can’t get involved in this? Something terrible has happened to that young woman and everyone is quiet even though we all know that she doesn’t have anyone to help her in this country. Didn’t Susan say she came here with her sister to look for work? Two girls without their family! Some of us have daughters the same age. How would we feel if it happened to them?”

“Florence, you heard what Susan said. The girl is wayward. This is what happens to girls like that.”

“Wayward? Because she has a boyfriend? What is wayward about that? And even if she is wayward, does that mean she should be raped? Are we now saying that any girl or

woman who doesn't do as she is told should be raped? Is that where we have reached?" she asked angrily, not caring that Salome was giving her a lift.

"That is not what I'm saying but we need to think about the girl...she never once attended church. Never came to church with Susan! Always spent Sundays in bed or with that boy. That's the kind of person we are talking about."

"Salome, are you hearing yourself?"

"Of course I am. She could even be lying, we don't know."

"What reason does she have to lie? You think reporting rape is an easy thing? Do you know what women who report rape go through? It's what is happening to Adanna now. Why would anyone put themselves through that?"

"Maybe she wants money from him. When we were leaving, I overheard Ophelia say that the boy comes from a good family."

"It's OK, drop me here," Florence said. They were at Adenta Junction, about ten minutes away from her house.

"Ah, you don't want me to take you home?"

"No, I want to walk," she said, already holding the door handle, desperate to get away from Salome and the rubbish she was spewing.

"Thank you," she said, without looking back, when she got out of the car.

At home, she told her husband what had happened.

"I have to do something for that girl," she told him.

"Florence, why are you now carrying this matter on your head? You don't know the girl from anywhere. And you know these Nigerians, you know how they are."

"Don't say that, Godfred. You can't paint everyone with the same brush. Besides, you know what happened to me. You know I didn't have anyone to stand up for me. I can't fold my

arms and let the girl suffer like this.”

Godfred exhaled loudly and folded his arms. “So, what are you going to do?” he finally said.

She didn’t like that he’d said ‘you’ instead of ‘we,’ but at least he was no longer opposing her. “I’m not sure. If she wants, we can go to the police. You know the police can make things worse. Sometimes they treat the rapist better than the victim, so who knows if she will even want to report it? First thing tomorrow, I will talk to Naa. Since she’s a queenmother, she will have some advice.”

“Aren’t there some Nigerians that can help? You can’t do all this by yourself.”

“There are, but I don’t know if they will help,” she said, thinking about her last conversation with Salome. “I don’t know.”

Later in bed, Florence thought about her own experience. Seventeen at the time, she’d been too afraid to speak up, because like James, the boy was from a prominent family, and she had feared that people, including her parents, would blame her for willingly going to his house. It wasn’t until she married Godfred that she’d felt safe to reveal what had happened, confident that he wouldn’t fault her for being victimised. She hadn’t been able to get justice for herself, but would get it for Adanna.

The next day, before going to her kiosk in Adenta market where she sold fabric, she stopped by Susan’s house and got Adanna’s number from the security man.

Adanna was lying in her sister’s bed, missing her mother’s embrace and the warmth of their cramped three-bedroom house, when the phone rang. Amara had already left for work.

“Adanna, this is Florence.”

Adanna sat up. “Florence?”

"Susan's friend, from church."

"Aunty Florence!"

"How are you?"

"Please I'm fine."

"Susan told us what happened. Can you come to my kiosk today in the market? I want to talk with you."

"To talk?" Adanna said, fearing that the woman wanted to lecture her, maybe tell her she got what she deserved.

"Yes, to see how I can help you."

"Ok."

Adanna wasn't sure what to expect when she climbed into the pale blue kiosk, which was lined with shelves of fabric. Florence, a thin woman with a kind face, was serving a customer, who was buying two yards of fabric, so Adanna had to wait. After the man left, Florence pointed to a bench and Adanna sat down.

"How are you? Florence said, sitting opposite her.

"Please, I'm fine," she said, though she no longer remembered how it felt to be fine.

"I'm going to call one of my friends, she's a queenmother. She can advise us. Is that OK?"

Adanna nodded, still puzzled about what was happening.

Florence stepped out and returned about two minutes later with another woman, slightly older, a scarf tight around her head.

"This is Naa. She's the local queenmother."

"Good afternoon," Adanna said, regarding both women with some suspicion.

"If you don't mind, can you tell us what happened?" Florence said.

Adanna hesitated, not wanting to relive that morning in James' house, but there was something about how softly

Florence spoke, and how she tilted her head, that made Adanna begin to recount the incident. When she finished, Florence held her hand and said, "I'm so sorry," while Naa nodded sympathetically.

It was then that she began to cry. Because apart from her sister, no one had said that to her. Her sister's roommates had been so matter-of-fact, as if a rape wasn't a big deal, as if it was something that people simply moved on from. It felt good to have someone speak to her with kindness and recognise that she had been deeply wronged. She felt like the two women could see her, and for the first time since she left James' house, the throbbing in her head began to subside.

"Thank you, Aunt," she said.

"What do you want?" the queenmother said.

"I want them to arrest him. He shouldn't go free after what he's done to me."

Both women nodded. "I can't leave my stall now, but Florence will take you to the police station and I'll watch her shop," the queenmother said. "What has happened is not right. That young man should be punished to set an example to others," she continued.

At the station, Florence and Adanna had to wait for over an hour to file the complaint, the sneering policewoman on duty repeatedly asking Adanna to recount what had happened in James' house as if she doubted Adanna's account. Florence had to call Naa who then reached out to a friend who knew a policeman at the station. It was only when he got involved that the policewoman seemed to take the case seriously and began taking down notes. Before they left, the policeman advised them to bring a medical report.

"It's been so long, they'll only find the scratches," Adanna said to Florence as they walked out of the police station.

"The doctors know what to look for, don't worry,"

Florence assured her.

“Thank you, Aunty,” Adanna said to her at the bus stop where they were waiting to catch a bus to the clinic. She didn’t understand why Florence was helping her, but was grateful. Standing beside Florence as passing trotros honked loudly to attract customers, she smiled for the first time in days.

The next day, Florence went to the women’s prayer service after work, and when the session was over, announced to the group that she had taken Adanna to report the assault to the police.

“You did what?” Susan said, scrunching her nose until it was a knob. She had on a trouser suit and was balancing on pencil heels that would have toppled a less determined woman.

“I went with her...”

“I heard you,” Susan snapped. “What business of yours is it? Who sent you?”

“What do you mean, who sent me? Are we not Christians? Doesn’t that mean that we are automatically sent to help people? Or isn’t that what Jesus says in that bible that you are holding?” Florence said, pointing to Susan’s gold trimmed bible.

“Are you the one to tell me what’s in the bible?”

“I have to, because you obviously don’t know what’s inside.”

She then turned to the other women, about twenty of them, tired after a long day of work and now caught in the middle of this disagreement between the most powerful woman in the group and the most fearless. “And all of you here, every Sunday you come to pray, Wednesday evening you come to pray again, every day you are calling Jesus’ name, but when a young woman is raped and then thrown out of her home, you can’t even open your mouth to say it’s wrong. What

kind of Christianity are you practising?”

None of the women answered but Susan sucked her teeth.

“And you have allowed this woman to take over our group, she said, a forefinger pointed at a scowling Susan. “This woman who has no empathy in her heart, no mercy. How can she lead a group of Christians? As long as she’s the leader, I cannot be a part of this group.”

“Oh, Sister Florence,” Salome said as Florence began walking out.

Florence glared at her and Salome swallowed whatever she was going to say next.

No one else spoke or followed Florence out. She was certain that they would begin a meeting to discuss her as soon as she was out of sight.

At the bus stop, she couldn’t help but smile, happy to finally be free of those women.

She was up early the next day. Naa, the queenmother, had phoned late last night to tell her that the police planned to arrest James today. This was after Naa had contacted everyone in her network who could pressure the police to take the case seriously. Adanna insisted on coming when Florence called and told her about the arrest.

“I want to be there when they take him,” she said.

“Are you sure?” Florence asked

“Yes!”

“OK, meet me at my kiosk at 6.”

Florence was leaving the house at dawn to catch a bus when Salome’s car pulled up.

“Salome, what are you doing here?”

“I couldn’t sleep, Sister Florence, after what you said at the church.”

“Hmm.”

“How are you?”

“I’m fine.”

There was an awkward silence as they stood by Salome’s car, staring at each other.

Then Florence spoke. “They are going to arrest the man this morning, the rapist. I’m going to get Adanna first and we’ll go to the police station.”

“I will drop you,” Salome said eagerly.

Adanna and Naa were waiting for them at the kiosk and climbed into the vehicle. At the police station, they had to give the officers money for petrol before the three men and one woman entered the police car. Salome drove behind them.

In the backseat, Adanna’s heart was pounding. She was afraid to see James again, afraid of his anger that she knew would be on display, afraid of his sister who would surely call Adanna a liar, but her need for justice was greater than her fear. She didn’t realise she was shaking until the queenmother put a hand on her knee, as if to still her.

They parked in front of James’ house and unfortunately for him, he was the one who answered when the police rang the bell. When he spotted Adanna, he tried to dart back into the compound, but the policeman nearest to the gate grabbed his arm and pulled him out.

“Leave me,” he began to shout, but they were already putting handcuffs on him. Satisfaction made Adanna stand up straight by the car.

His sister came running out, “What’s happening here?” she said, but no one answered her. The officers were already shoving James into their car.

“You!” she said, turning to Adanna, who was standing between Naa and Florence. Adanna felt herself begin to wilt, to become small, the satisfaction from a moment before snuffed

out.

“Hey, hey!” Florence said, as James’ sister, her face taut with rage, approached Adanna with one hand raised.

The woman stopped and her hand fell to her side, but she was not done. “You will see what we will do to you. If you think we will stand by for you to destroy my brother’s life, then you don’t know who we are, you don’t know our family.”

“You also don’t know who we are,” Florence said. “We will not back down today, we will not back down tomorrow,” she continued as Naa and Salome nodded. Adanna’s heart did a funny dance, as if celebrating the support of these women.

“OK, we’ll see,” James’ sister said.

“Ehn, we will see. Isn’t that why we have eyes?” Florence replied. Adanna smiled shakily at that bit.

When James’ sister dashed back into the house, probably to call for reinforcement, Adanna hugged Florence.

“Thank you. All of you, thank you,” she said, holding the woman tightly. “Thank you for seeing me, for not leaving me to suffer. Thank you.”

“You don’t have to thank us,” Florence said as she patted Adanna’s back.

“What will happen now?” Adanna asked, when she pulled away.

“Well, this is the criminal justice system in Ghana so everything will move very very slowly, but don’t worry, we will be with you. I know some legal aid people that can also help,” Naa said.

“I also know a Nigerian group that helps our people in Madina, I will introduce you to them,” Salome said and then looked uneasily at Florence, as if she wasn’t sure she was allowed to speak. But Florence nodded her approval.

Adanna smiled, grateful, because she had no idea what to do. Neither did she have the resources to do it.

“And you can come and be assisting me in the kiosk

and earning a bit of money until you find another job,” Florence said.

Adanna hugged Florence again, this time there were tears in her eyes.

When they were seated in Salome’s car and driving back to the market, Florence turned to Salome and said, “So, are you going to tell your church sisters about this?”

Salome hesitated and then shook her head, “I don’t think I’ll be going back to that group.”

“Good. There’s no law that says there can be only one women’s group in the church. We will form our own group,” Florence said.

Salome nodded and behind them, Adanna smiled. A women’s group led by Florence was one she would like to join.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Peace Adzo Medie is a scholar and a writer. She studies state and non-state actors' responses to gender-based violence and other forms of insecurity. Her book, *'Global Norms and Local Action: The Campaigns to End Violence Against Women in Africa,'* was published by Oxford University Press in 2020. Her debut novel, *His Only Wife*, was a New York Times Notable Book of 2020, a New York Times Book Review Editors' Choice, and a Time Magazine Must-Read Book of 2020. It was also a Reese's Book Club pick. Her second novel, *Nightbloom*, was longlisted for the 2024 Women's Prize for Fiction. Her short stories have appeared in Transition, Four Way Review, Slice Magazine, and elsewhere. She is associate professor in politics at the University of Bristol.

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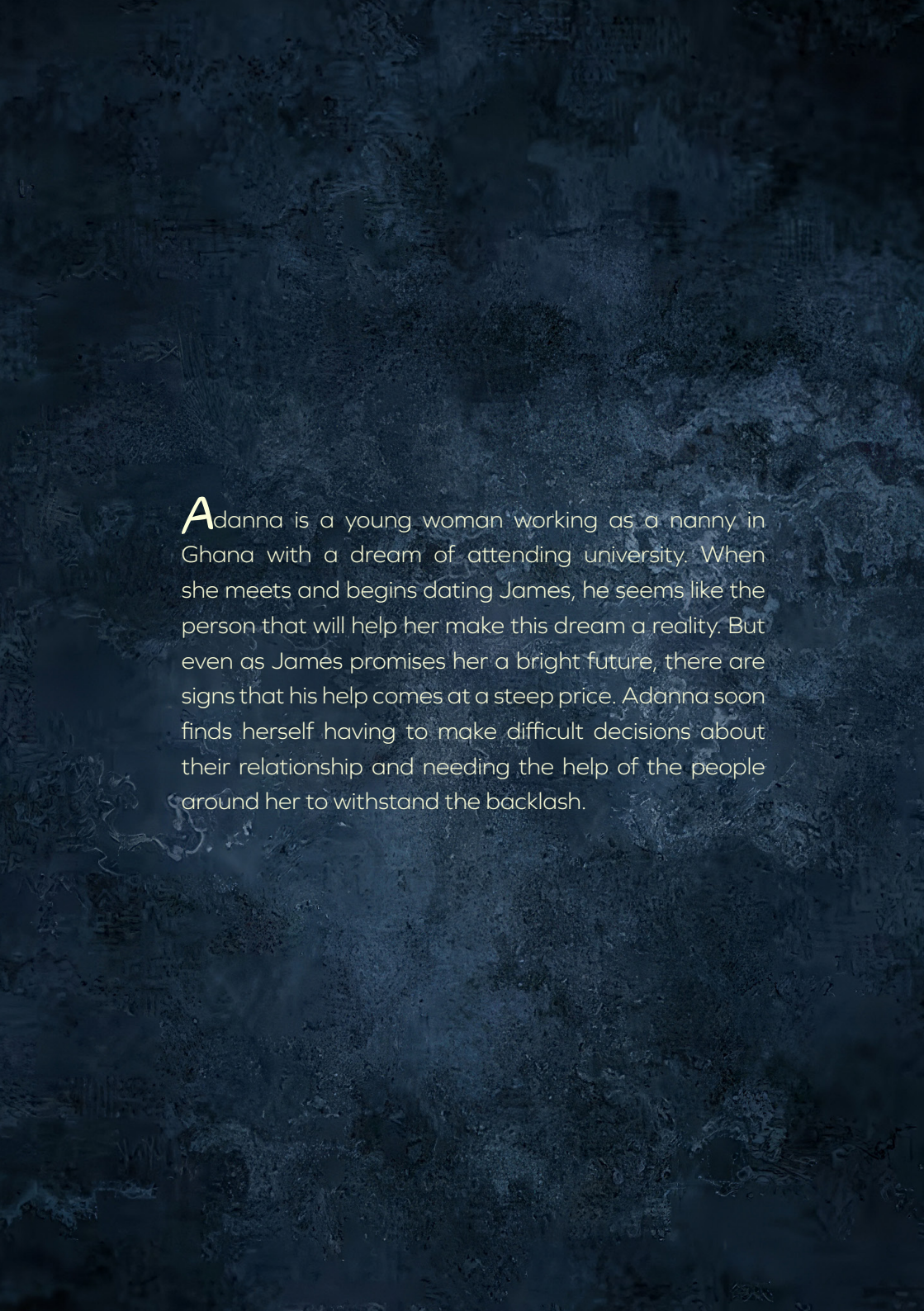
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Adanna is a young woman working as a nanny in Ghana with a dream of attending university. When she meets and begins dating James, he seems like the person that will help her make this dream a reality. But even as James promises her a bright future, there are signs that his help comes at a steep price. Adanna soon finds herself having to make difficult decisions about their relationship and needing the help of the people around her to withstand the backlash.